

K-12 SCHOOL RATINGS

SUMMARY

1:1 user interviews designed to get quick and clean insights about what information is needed to understand school ratings and whether that information is understandable.

IMPACT

Rolled out in September 2024

-  Reduced frequency of user misunderstandings by 80% on school ratings.
-  16% increase in clicks on school profiles each month.

CONTEXT & RESEARCH PLAN

Company	GreatSchools.org
Role	Lead UX Researcher
Timeline	Three weeks
Stakeholders	Product Manager, Data Scientist, Designer



Problem

- 1.Engineering planned to make school profiles more interactive in order to increase ad revenue and gather more usage data.
- 2.Stakeholders were confident our ratings were easy-to-use for parents.
- 3.But previous research suggested parents are sometimes unsure, sometimes misinterpret school ratings, like “8/10 test scores”.

Research questions

- 1.What information about school ratings is needed to pick a school?
- 2.Is that information easy to comprehend?

My approach

Method

- 1:1 user interviews
 - What questions would you ask about these ratings to decide if you would consider this school?
 - For each question, shared a drafted answer and got feedback

Analysis

- Matrix analysis in Google Sheets

Recruitment

- Three rounds of n=5 participants
- Parents in the US who were sending their kid(s) to a new school in the fall

Collaboration

- Asked stakeholders about their concerns during Zoom calls
- “Soft-launching” insights in Confluence to prevent PM from being blindsided
- Shared final report in a slide deck

FINDING	RECOMMENDATION	IMPACT
One answer was disappointing - users didn't want schools to be compared across the entire state.	Out-of-scope for this project, but change the roadmap to move away from state-wide ratings to more local options.	• Small-scale and large-scale changes are in progress and in the backlog - unfortunately both are under NDA.
Some answers were understandable, but led to new questions.	Use a progressive disclosure interface to guide users away from "rabbit holes."	Rolled out in September 2024 to 500k unique monthly users • 80% decrease in frequency of user misunderstandings. • 16% YoY increase in clicks on school profiles.
One new question came up.	Draft new content, conduct usability test.	
Clear understanding of what data is needed for users' jobs-to-be-done.	Decision to move forward with prototype a design, build it, and roll out the new version.	